

Text One

Buried treasure is real – this is how to find it and whether you have to give it back

adapted from an article by James Andrews

In this passage, the writer gives advice to treasure hunters in the United Kingdom.



In 2014, Derek McLennan found a Viking¹ treasure hoard of gold, silver, textiles and jewels in Scotland. He got £2million out of it. The same year David Blakey found almost 2,000 Roman coins in East Yorkshire – worth an estimated £44,000. But they were both beaten by Reg Mead and Richard Miles who found an astonishing 50,000 Celtic² coins worth £10 million under a hedge in Jersey, in the Channel Islands, where they'd been hidden from the Romans 2,000 years ago. And they're far from alone – with almost 1.3 million finds uncovered in the 20 years since the Treasure Act was brought into force in Britain, 82,272 of them in 2015 alone.

5

The lesson? Buried treasure is not only real, but still being uncovered at a fast rate in Britain. But – lacking a map with a handily placed 'X', how do you find buried treasure and can you keep it if you do?

10

Step 1 – get equipped

People buried treasure for a reason – which means they often buried it deep. That means you need a metal detector that can reach that far. The best detectors can penetrate more than a metre into the ground, and will even tell you the sort of metal they find – so you know exactly when you strike gold. But these don't come cheap – while you can pick up a metal detector for less than £30, a good one will cost around £200. A GPS unit is something else that's popular with treasure hunters – this lets them plot the position of their finds as well as ensuring you don't end up searching the same area twice by mistake. You should probably pack a small shovel too, and possibly a trowel for small holes and a brush to clean your finds. There's also a case for a smaller, hand-held detector, so you can save time finding the metal you're looking for once you've dug your hole.

15

20

Step 2 – get permission

Going onto someone else's land without permission is at best trespassing and would be theft if you do make a find and remove it. However, landowners are frequently fine with you looking for things on their land – and a verbal agreement that you share the value of what you find with them is often enough. 25

Step 3 – look after what you find

You've heard the tell-tale beep, dug up a purse of gold and then... What exactly?

Inexperienced treasure hunters might drop the coins into a pocket, but with finds often fragile and old coins and jewellery easily damaged, it makes sense to have something that protects them. You can buy a special pouch for finds but you can put them in a cotton-wool lined tin or box you have brought with you. 30

Step 4 – report it

If you find treasure, you have to report it. 35

In fact, there's an unlimited fine and up to three months in prison for people who don't. A former policeman was recently jailed for 16 months after not only lying about where his coins came from, but for selling them on. The Treasure Valuation Committee – made up of independent experts – decides what your find is worth if a museum wants to take it off your hands, with the money shared between you and the owner of the land. If not, the treasure is returned to you. 40

What counts as treasure then?

Under the Treasure Act, if you find any of the following you have to report them:

- Any metallic object, other than a coin, provided that at least 10% by weight of metal is precious metal (that is, gold or silver) and that it is at least 300 years old when found. If the object is of prehistoric date it will be Treasure provided any part of it is precious metal. 45
- Any group of two or more metallic objects (of any composition) of prehistoric date that come from the same find.
- Two or more coins from the same find provided they are at least 300 years old when found and contain 10% gold or silver. 50
- Any object, whatever it is made of, that is found in the same place as, or had previously been together with, another object that is defined as Treasure. Finds may have become scattered since they were originally deposited in the ground.

Where to look for treasure 55

Treasure hunting in the city is a bit of a lost cause – generations of building and other human activities make finding something almost impossible. In fact, most of the big city finds are uncovered by professional archaeologists – who don't even get to keep them. That means that most of the major finds happen out in the countryside, generally on agricultural land. 60

As to where in the country is best, analysis of the finds reported over the past 20 years shows Norfolk has produced the most finds – at 1,292 discoveries – followed by Yorkshire, Suffolk and Lincolnshire.

- ¹ *Viking* – warriors from Scandinavia who invaded Europe and Great Britain in the 8th to 11th centuries
- ² *Celtic* – Celtic people who lived in Cornwall, Scotland, Wales, Ireland and the Channel Islands

Text Two

Lost treasures and how to find them

adapted from an article by Graham Seal, Professor of Folklore, Curtin University, Australia

In this passage, the writer presents treasure hunting as being based mainly on myths and legends.



A lost Nazi¹ gold train was discovered in Poland. At least, that's what a couple of treasure hunters told the world last year. Like all lost treasures, the search for this one had been going on for many years, usually without success. But many still believe in these far-fetched stories and some even search for the treasure.

It was believed locally that possibly three trains stuffed with stolen gold, jewels and art were buried in a complex of tunnels under construction by The Third Reich² for still-unknown purposes. The train, or trains, were then sealed in, awaiting only intrepid treasure seekers to unearth their riches. People have been looking for years but no one has succeeded in the quest.

Armed with the latest techno gadgets and a map, the raiders of the lost Nazi treasure claimed to have found their prize. They were prepared to reveal its location in return for a modest percentage of the finds. Local officials apparently fell in with this nonsense and the Deputy Polish Culture Minister was widely quoted saying that they were 99% sure the train was there.

Enter the spoilsport scientists from the Krakow Mining Academy. *Their* techno gadgets confirmed that not only was there no hidden Nazi train of gold but there were not even any real railway tracks in this region. Just empty tunnels.

Still, even if that one was dispelled by science, people love a lost treasure story.

Colonel Percy Fawcett went to Brazil's Mato Grosso searching for the lost city of 'Z' in 1925. He has not been seen since. A Hollywood film about the Lost City of Z – co-produced by Brad Pitt and starring Robert Pattinson and Sienna Miller appeared in our cinemas 91 years after Fawcett disappeared.

Lost treasure tales have a number of common elements that provide them with apparent credibility.

Firstly, they are in remote or otherwise difficult to access locations. Lasseter's Reef is said to lie somewhere in some of Australia's most desolate emptiness. South American jungles have harboured any number of fabulous Aztec, Incan or Mayan³ treasure troves. Islands are excellent, especially for pirate treasure chests. 25

Then there will be a map. Or sometimes another document, like a letter, giving the vague location of the hidden treasure. Harold (originally Hubert) Lasseter left a diary and a map of his fabled reef as he lay dying in 1931. Many have since used these documents in futile attempts to find the gold. 30

The map or document will have an obscure origin. It may come from a previous seeker of a particular rumoured treasure. It might be helpfully 'found', preferably in an atmospheric location. Tombs are good. 35

Usually the person who provides the document to the treasure seeker will be conveniently dead, as in the Beale ciphers. The Beale ciphers are three papers written in code, one of which will reveal the location of treasure buried in Bedford County, Virginia, USA. No one has yet cracked the code, although claims of success have been made.

Then there will be guardians of the lost treasure. Often these are primitive savages who will stop at nothing to prevent intrepid treasure hunters getting to their fabled hoard. One explanation for the disappearance of Colonel Percy Fawcett in the Amazon is that he was killed by local people. Indiana Jones (the fictional adventurer and treasure hunter who appeared in the film *Raiders of the Lost Ark*) is often said to be based on the British explorer's exploits, though a version of this character appears in other lost treasure tales. 40 45

The final feature of lost treasure tales is the unsuccessful but tantalisingly promising attempts of earlier searchers to reach the hoard. The notion that something must be there because so many have tried before is a mainspring of the mythology that supports these persistent folk beliefs.

Believers still risk their lives in search of Lasseter's Reef. Others are still burrowing for treasures on Oak Island off Nova Scotia and any number of sunken galleons and other wrecks are still the object of fervent searches in all of the seven seas. 50

Every now and then one of these expeditions actually strikes gold, as in the recent rediscovery of a Spanish treasure ship off Colombia. In March 2016, divers recovered sunken treasure from a 500-year-old shipwreck off the coast of Oman, giving hope to all the other hunters out there. The rarity of these finds and the sensations they produce are sufficient to stoke the fires of hope that glitter in the hearts of all treasure hunters. 55

It might just be that the legend is true...

¹ *Nazi* – term used to refer to the followers of Hitler in World War Two

² *The Third Reich* – the name for the administration in Germany from January 1933 to May 1945 60

³ *Aztec, Incan or Mayan* – civilisations in Mexico and in Central and South America between 1,800 and 500 years ago